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The concluding portion of Abul Fazl's *Ain-i-Akbari* contains an extensive account of the thoughts and customs of India. No previous effort of this nature and scale was made earlier after that 'great moment in World History' when one of the most outstanding scientists of the Islamic Civilization, Alberuni, set himself to study, expound and analyse the religion and sciences of India in the eleventh century. Abul Fazl's own English translator Jarrett tells us how much Alberuni's work is superior to Abul Fazl's. Without contesting the essence of this judgement one would still argue that (a) while Abul Fazl has derived and 'processed' some material from Alberuni, the bulk of his information comes from newly tapped independent sources and (b) the purpose of the two works are different: Alberuni's to elaborate, understand and criticise, Abul Fazl's to describe and summarise. What is important to us to consider the first of these two reservations? If Abul Fazl had independent sources, what were these?

It is clear from Abul Fazl's account that a considerable part of his information came from oral testimony of the learned among the Brahmans and Jains. We know from Jain accounts that Abul Fazl was throughout in close touch with them just as he was with the Jesuit Fathers.

But another part of the information came from fresh material translated from Sanskrit. The project of translating Sanskrit works at Akbar's Court has been commented upon by such a large number of modern scholars that I claim no discovery here. What I propose to do in this paper is to go all over the Persian evidence for this remarkable endeavour and present it here, throughout in fresh translation and, hopefully, with a few new additional data.

The effort at translating Ancient Indian works began with the arrival of Shaikh Bhawan at Akbar's Court in A.H. 983/1575–76. Badauni tells us:

In this year Shaikh Bhawan, who was a Brahman scholar, came from the countries of Deccan to take service at Court. Having volun-

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tarily obtained the honour of accepting Islam, he joined the circle of the personal attendants (*Khasa-Khailan*) of His Majesty. His Majesty ordered that the *Atharva-Veda* ('Bed Atharban'), which is the fourth one out of the four celebrated books of the Indians, and some of whose injunctions are like those of the Muslim Community, should be explained, and I should render it from the Indian language into Persian. Since there were many obscurities in the text, and the interpreter (Shaikh Bhawan) was unable to explain them, and the intention could not be understood, I reported this to the Emperor. (Thereupon) first, Shaikh Faizi and then Haji Ibrahim Sirhindi was ordered to translate it. He did not render it in a satisfactory manner, and no trace of the work for this reason survives.¹

One of the reasons the translation did not give satisfaction was, perhaps, because, with the zeal of a convert, Shaikh Bhawan sought to give to the *Atharva-Veda* text meanings which might please his coreligionists. For Badauni goes on to say:

One of the many injunctions of that work is this that until they recite a text that has several *la* letters and sounds like the Muslim confession of faith *la ilaha il l'allah* (There is no god but God), they could not receive salvation. Secondly, beef is permitted upon certain conditions. Further the dead are to be buried, not burnt. Shaikh Bhawan used to come out victorious in debate with the Brahmans of all India; and out of this motive had accepted the True Faith. God be praised.²

On this it is fitting to record a rival though later tradition recorded, c. 1653:

Nain Jot says, I said (to Shaikh Bawan, name so spelt). "Translate this passage." When he translated it, its meaning appeared to be wholly contrary and opposite to the meaning of *la ilaha il l'allah*. More, those conditions of beef-eating were contrary to the way of the Muslims. Further, the way of burial was in a different fashion, which is not permitted among the Muslims. His Majesty and all those present laughed at the Brahman (convert), and His Majesty said: "Look at the Muslims and Hindus, that during such a long argument, no one asked, what the meaning of this text is." He praised me considerably.³

The date when the translation was completed cannot be precisely established, but Shaikh Ibrahim Sirhindi died in 1583; and so the work must have been finished before this year.⁴ It must, therefore have been the earliest work of translation from Sanskrit into Persian. Owing to the difficulties posed by its archaic language, the choice was, perhaps not a fortunate one, being dictated more by Shaikh

Bhawan's assertiveness, in the beginning, than by any independent indication of its contents.

Badauni is, however, not right in saying that the translation was so unsatisfactory as to be forgotten. Abul Fazl records in the *Ain-i Akbari* (c. 1595) that among the important works translated upon Akbar's orders was 'the book *Atharban*, which, according to the beliefs of these people, is one of the four Divine Books, (and which) was translated by Haji Ibrahim Sirhindi into Persian.'⁵ No manuscript of this is, however, known to exist.

The second major work to be translated was the immensely long and rich compilation, the *Mahabharata*. The work started in A.H. 990/1582, and Badauni, again, is our main informant as to how it began. Writing under the year A.H. 990/1582, he says:

Collecting together the learned men of India, His Majesty directed that the book *Mahabharat* should be translated. For some nights His Majesty personally (had it) explained to Naqib Khan, who wrote out the resultant text in Persian. On the third night His Majesty summoned me and ordered me to translate it in collaboration with Naqib Khan. In three or four months out of the eighteen chapters (*fan*) of that stock of useless fables, at which eighteen worlds may remain in wonderment, I wrote out two chapters. And what censures I did not hear (from Akbar), so that the accusations that I am an 'unlawful earner' or 'a turnip eater' (apparently expressions used by Akbar) meant as if my destiny from these books was just this. Destiny is destiny! Thereafter Mulla Shiri and Naqib Khan completed that section, and one section Sultan Haji Thanesari 'Munfarid' brought to completion. Shaikh Faizi was then appointed to write it in verse and prose, but he too did not complete more than two Chapters (*fan*). Again, the said Haji wrote out two sections and rectified the errors which were committed in the first round, and fitting one part with another, compiled a hundred fasciculi. The direction was to establish exactitude in a minute manner so that nothing of the original should be lost. In the end upon some fault, His Majesty ordered him (Haji Thanesari) to be dismissed and sent away to Bhakkar, his native city, where he still is. Most of the interpreters and translators are in hell along with Korus and Pandavs, and as for the remaining ones, may God save them, and mercifully destine them to repent. . . . His Majesty named the work *Razmnaama* (Epic), and had it illustrated and transcribed in many copies, and the nobles too were ordered to have it transcribed by way of obtaining blessings. Shaikh Abul Fazl, contrary to the dictates of the commentary on the Quranic '*Ayat al-Kursi*' that he had composed, wrote a preface of the length of two quires (*juzv*) for that work.⁶

Badauni's passage ought to be read with two other texts. One is the afterword in the British Mus. MS. of the *Razmnama* of Akbar's library, transcribed in A.H. 1007/1598–99, containing chapters (*fan*) XIV–XVIII, i.e. the last portion.⁷ The concluding chapter XVIII is very short and the afterword which comes at the end is unfortunately damaged, and some portions cannot be restored. It tells us that the work was commissioned by Akbar on Monday 9 Ramzan (year lost). If the year was 990 A.H./1582 as stated by Badauni, the date would be 27 September 1582. The writer of the afterword is Naqib Khan himself (Naqib Khan, son of 'Abdul Latif al Hasani'). 'He translated it from Sanskrit into the Persian language in the space of one and a half years. Some Brahmans, namely, Rana . . . Sita, Rani, Madas, Nahar, Chitrabhoj Sen, and Shaikh Bhawan, who with His Majesty's attention, has become honoured by having accepted Islam, read that book and explained it to this sinful author in Hindi, and the author wrote it down in Persian'.⁸

This has the merit of telling us that the translation was carried out, Sanskrit being rendered into Hindi by a set of pundits and the Hindi then rendered into Persian. Unfortunately, the afterword is not dated; but assuming that the translation began in 1582, the work should have finished in 1584.

The second is the brief reference in the *Ain-i Akbari*. The book *Mahabharat*, one of the ancient books of Hindustan, was translated from Hindi into Persian by Naqib Khan, Maulana Abdul Qadir Badauni, and Shaikh Sultan Thanisari. It comprises some one lakh couplets. His Majesty named this ancient epic *Razmnama*.⁹

A little later, the *Ain*, puts the *Razmnama* among those works which were illustrated by Akbar's painters.¹⁰

The work was certainly complete by 1591, when Akbar sent Prince Murad a copy of the *Razmnama*.¹¹ It seems, however, that portions went on being read aloud to Akbar, and it was through this that an embarrassing situation arose for Badauni in 1595. On the occasion of Nauroz (20 March 1595), Akbar complained to Abul Fazl that Badauni, whom he had thought to be of mystical bent, was really a 'fanatical theologian' (*faqih-i muta'ssib*). He had let his orthodoxy led him to insert into the portion of the *Razmnama* rendered by him, the concept of the Day of Judgement, which was alien to the Indians who believed in transmigration of souls (*tanasukh*). Badauni had much to do to explain that he had not deviated from the duty of the translator and that Indians did believe that heaven and hell existed as intermediate stages in transmigrations.¹²

Many manuscripts of the *Razmnama* exist.¹³

Abul Fazl says that 'the same persons (who had translated the *Razmnama*) also rendered into Persian the book *Ramayan*, which is one of the ancient compilations of India. It contains the detailed

narrative of the life of Ramchandar, and records many unique points of wisdom.'¹⁴ Badauni suggests, however, that he alone was the translator, and that the work began in A.H. 992/1584.

At this time His Majesty ordered me to translate the book *Ramayan*, which is older than the *Mahabharat*. It has 25000 *shloks*, and every *shlok* is a sentence of 65 letters. It is the tale of Ramchandar, *raja* of Awadh (Ayodhya), who is also called Ram, and Hindus worshipped him as an Incarnation of God . . . (*Ramayana* story summarized).⁵

Badauni claims he was able to translate the work in four years; but there is, perhaps, some error in his counting because he was able to present his translation to Akbar only in early 1591. We have the following characteristic passage:

In the month of Jumada I 999 (February-March 1591) having translated the book *Ramayan* in the space of four years and made a copy of the whole, I submitted it to His Majesty. Since in the end I had written (the couplet,)

We wrote a tale to the Sultan who fulfils (our wishes)

We burnt up our life for he who gives lives, His Majesty was very pleased, and asked, 'How many quires (*juzv*) it has come to?' I replied, 'In the first instance in summary, nearly seventy quires, then, in the detailed translation, 120 quires.' His Majesty said, 'Write a preface, after the fashion of authors.' Since it had hardly any fare, and I would have to write a preface without any prefatory praise of the Prophet (*na't*), I dissimulated. From that black test, as destructive as my life, I seek refuge with God (But) copying infidelity is not infidelity. . . .¹⁶

Manuscripts of this translation also survive, one with 176 full-page paintings (from Akbar's atelier?) in the Jaipur Palace.¹⁷ Abul Fazl, indeed, records that the *Ramayan* too was illustrated for Akbar's library.¹⁸

The *Yogavasishta* is an appendix to the *Ramayana* dealing with 'all manners of topics including final release.'¹⁹ It is possible that Abul Fazl had this text in mind when he referred to 'the many unique points of wisdom' in connexion with the *Ramayana*.²⁰ But otherwise he does not seem to refer to this text. But manuscripts exist of a translation by Nizam Panipati, prepared with the help of two pundits, and dedicated to Prince Salim.²¹ It must, therefore, have been prepared before 1605. Whether this was received at Akbar's court is, however, uncertain.

'The *Haribans* (*Hari-vamsa*) which consists of an account of Kishan (Krishna) Mulla Shiri translated into Persian.'²² We know that Mulla Shiri was a poet of some repute, though not a scholar, at Akbar's court.²³ But unluckily no manuscript of this translation appear to have survived.

The work of translation was extended to non-religious literature as well:

The *Lilavati*, which from amongst the works from the pen of the learned of India in Arithmetic (*hisab*), (my) elder brother Shaikh Abul Faiz Faizi transferred it from a Hindi to a Persian garb; and the book *Tajik*, which on the science of astronomy is a reliable authority, was translated into Persian by Mukammal Khan Gujarati, at His Majesty's instance.²⁴

This is Bhaskaracharya's celebrated work. Faizi's translation is extant in several manuscript copies, and two editions (1827, 1854–5) exist. The year (A.H. 995/1507) when the translation was completed is apparently given in the preface, which begins with the praise of Akbar.²⁵

Of the second translated work no extant manuscript appears to be recorded. It could be a translation of the Sanskrit work the astronomer Nilkantha wrote on *Jyotish* at Akbar's court, the *Tajikanilkanthi* in Saka 1509/1587.²⁶

Abul Fazl also mentions the translation of Kalhana's *Rajatarangini*, the celebrated history of Kashmir:

The History of Kashmir, which contains the annals of four thousand years of that country Maulana Shah Muhammad Shahabadi rendered from the language of Kashmir (sic! Sanskrit) into Persian.²⁷

When Badauni in 1595 saved himself from Imperial wrath over a suspected inaccuracy in his translation of the *Mahabharat*, he had hoped that he would get a suitable post elsewhere and leave the Court with its heretical ways; but Akbar had other ideas:

His Majesty (in Ramazan 1003/May–June 1595) told Shaikh Abul Fazl in my presence, 'Although he (Badauni) would also have served well at the post in Ajmer, yet whenever we give him something to translate, he does it very well and to our satisfaction. We do not wish that he should be separated from us.' Shaikh and others confirmed this. The same day, it was ordered that the Hindi annals, which Sultan Zainul Abidin had translated in past and given the name of *Bahrul Asmar*, I should translate the remaining part and complete it, I was to complete the task in five months, since the latter portion of that work comprised 60 quires. Soon afterwards I was called at night to the throne in the Palace, and asked about the stories in each chapter till dawn. His Majesty said: Since in Part one which Sultan Zainul Abidin had had translated, the Persian is quite unidiomatic, you should write this out afresh in idiomatic language. . . .²⁸

Badauni was given 10,000 copper *tankas* and a horse in *inam*, and hoped to finish his task quickly in two or three months.²⁹ But he finished his *Tarikh* apparently before he finished his translation.

It is curious that Badauni does not refer to Shah Muhammad Shahabadi at all. The surviving manuscripts of the Persian *Rajatarangini* defective as they are, do not seem to elucidate the matter.³⁰ One possibility is that Shah Muhammad Shahabadi was the translator of the work under Zainul 'Abidin, and the work was merely transcribed for Akbar's library; in that case a slip must be assumed on the part of Abul Fazl. The task of a fresh rendering was assigned to Badauni, after the *Ain-i Akbari* had been completed, so that the new translation would not be mentioned by Abul Fazl at all.

I may mention that I exclude Faizi's *Nal Daman* from consideration here because it is not really a translation by a retelling in Persian of the Indian tale.

When one looks at Akbar's translation project, one realises that its centre piece is the *Mahabharata*; and it should therefore be of little surprise to us that the Vaishnavite facet of Hinduism was more prominent at Akbar's Court than the Saivite. The *Upanishads* and Sankaracharya are not represented. It was left to Akbar's great grandson Dara Shukoh, to add the *Upanishads* to the Brahmanical literature available in Persian, through a splendid translation, *Sirr-i-Akbar*. The scientific texts translated were also far too few. But it would be churlish to question the extent and coverage of Akbar's translation project in this manner. What stands out, when, to use Abul Fazl's favourite phrase, 'the veil is lifted', is the lofty vision and grandiose design of a shared, unified intellectual heritage of all mankind.

NOTES AND REFERENCES

1. Abdul Qadir Badauni, *Muntakhabut Tawarikh*, ed. Ali Ahamad and Lees, Bib. Ind. Calcutta, 1864-69, II, pp. 212-13
2. Ibid., II, p. 213.
3. Anonymous, *Dabistan-i-Mazahib*, Bombay ed; p. 265. I have not been able to identify Nain Jot, apparently a Brahman divine or scholar at Akbar's Court.
4. Abul Fazl, *Akbarnama*, Bib. Ind. Calcutta, 1873-87, III, pp. 408-9.
5. *Ain-i Akbari*, Blochmann, Calcutta, 1866-67, I, pp. 115-16.
6. Badauni, II, pp. 319-21.
7. Br.Mus.Or. 12,076. This MS is illustrated by Akbar's painters. The date of transcription is given at the end of Chapter (*fan*) XVII on f. 136a.
8. Br.Mus.Or. 12,076 f. 138b. It is interesting to find Shaikh Bhawan reappearing as a translator despite his misadventures with the *Atharva-Veda*.
9. *Ain-i Akbari*, p. 115.
10. *Ain*, I, pp. 117-18.
11. See an early version of the *Akbarnama*, cited by Iqtidar Alam Khan, 'Akbar's Personality Traits and World View,' Seminar on Akbar at Aligarh, 9-11 October 1992 (Unpublished).

12. *Badauni*, II, pp. 398–400.
13. See list in D.N. Marshall, *Mughals in India, a Bibliographical Survey*, Bombay, 1967, pp. 18–19.
14. *Ain-i Akbari*, I, pp. 115.
15. *Badauni*, II, pp. 336–7.
16. *Badauni*, II, p. 366.
17. Marshall, op.cit., p. 19.
18. *Ain-i Akbari*, p. 117.
19. A.B. Keith, *History of Sanskrit Literature*, Oxford, 1920, p. 480.
20. *Ain-i Akbari*, p. 115.
21. Marshall, op.cit., p. 377.
22. *Ain-i Akbari*, II, p. 116.
23. Nizamuddin Ahmad, *Tabaqat-i Akbari*, ed. B.De, II, Calcutta, 1931, pp. 490–91.
24. *Ain-i Akbari*, I, p. 116.
25. C.A. Storey, *Persian Literature, A Bibliographical Survey*, II (1), London, 1972, pp. 4–5.
26. See Marshall, op.cit., p. 374.
27. *Ain-i Akbari*, I, p. 116.
28. *Badauni*, II, pp. 401–2.
29. *Ibid*, p. 402.
30. Storey, op.cit., II (3) London, 1939, p. 679, where the year of Badauni's translation is wrongly given as 999/1590–91.